Making academic language and norms visible

Do I normalise unfamiliarity with academic language and norms?

LANGUAGE / TEACHING

ONE-PAGE TEACHING GUIDE

WHAT IS IT?

Unfamiliarity with norms and terminology is treated as normal, not a deficit

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

University contains many hidden rules: what “critical analysis” means, what a rubric is really asking for, when it is acceptable to ask for help, or what counts as “professional” behaviour. If those rules remain unspoken, familiarity can be mistaken for capability.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “Everyone else seems to know rules nobody has explained.”
- “I understand the topic, but not what I am being asked to do.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Invite students to ask about unfamiliar terms without embarrassment.
- Explain new terminology in context and return to it often.
- Avoid acting as though not knowing a convention means the student is not suited to the discipline.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A lecturer pauses on specialist terminology and explains both the term and how professionals actually use it.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

In this course, we aim to normalise unfamiliarity with academic language and explain university and disciplinary norms as learnable practices.

GO FURTHER AT UQ

View the Influential Communicators example

Inclusive practice

Digital Essentials